BY ORDER OF THE COMMANDER
AIR FORCE MATERIEL COMMAND



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Personnel

TEST EAGLE - AFMC FLIGHT TEST, TEST AND TEST WING OPERATIONS SUPPORT SQUADRON COMMANDER CANDIDATE SELECTION BOARD

COMPLIANCE WITH THIS PUBLICATION IS MANDATORY

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This instruction implements AFPD 36-26, *Total Force Development and Management*, and AFPD 36-21, *Utilization and Classification of Air Force Military Personnel,* and outlines and establishes policy, procedures, areas of responsibilities, and an event timeline for the command's operations squadron commander candidate selection board. It applies to all personnel involved with the nomination and board processes, candidate-select list, and board protocol. This publication does not apply to Air National Guard (ANG) or Air Force Reserve (AFRC) units. Ensure that all records created as a result of processes prescribed in this publication are maintained IAW Air Force Manual (AFMAN) 33-363, *Management of Records*, and disposed of IAW Air Force Records Information Management System (AFRIMS) Records Disposition Schedule (RDS) Refer recommended changes and questions about this publication to the Office of Primary Responsibility (OPR) using the AF Form 847, *Recommendation for Change of Publication*; route AF Forms 847 from the field through the appropriate functional chain of command. The authorities to waive wing/unit level requirements in this publication are identified with a Tier ("T-0, T-1, T-2, T-3") number following the compliance statement. See AFI 33-360, *Publications and Forms Management*, for a description of the authorities associated with the Tier numbers. Submit requests for waivers through the chain of command to the appropriate Tier waiver approval authority, or alternately, to the Publication OPR for non-tiered compliance items. This publication may not be supplemented or further implemented/extended. See **Attachment 1** for a glossary of references and supporting information.

SUMMARY OF CHANGES

This document is substantially revised and must be completely reviewed. A new Test Squadron command candidate application has been introduced, replacing the use of Form 3849 and Airmen Development Plans. The application scoring rubric has been added. The candidate selection process description has been abbreviated to allow flexibility in board execution.

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1. General.

1.1. **Squadron commander selection.** Hiring and tenure process outlined in this instruction is designed to give AFMC squadron command hiring authorities and senior raters maximum latitude for filling critical leadership positions.

1.2. This instruction establishes procedures for selection and conduct of the AFMC "Test Eagle" commander candidate selection board. The Test Eagle board will convene annually to identify candidates for projected commander vacancies in AFMC flight test squadrons, test squadrons, test wing operations support squadrons and any other requirements as directed by the AFMC Air, Space, and Cyberspace Operations Directorate (AFMC/A3/6). All other AFMC wings will choose operations support squadron commanders from the consolidated 13M command list.

2. Timing of Selection Board and Release of Consolidated Lists.

2.1. AFPC will release an annual personnel services delivery memorandum (PSDM) announcing the AFMC flight test squadron, test squadron and test wing operations support squadron command candidate selection board (Test Eagle) and establishing all applicable suspense dates.

2.2. All Test Eagle command selection board applications will be submitted to the AFMC Test and Evaluation Division (AFMC/A3F) via the Test Eagle organizational email account (**testeagle@us.af.mil**) by the date specified in the Test Eagle PSDM.

2.3. No later than two weeks after board completion, AFMC/A3F will provide board results to the Director of AFMC/A3/6 for approval and transmission to AFPC. The results will be released publicly via PSDM.

2.4. Once board results have been released, AFMC/A3F will facilitate the bid and match process for placement of selectees into command billets in the upcoming year.

3. Commander Candidate Eligibility Requirements.

3.1. **Acquisition Experience.** For those squadron commander positions that require acquisition experience, candidates must be acquisition qualified or eligible. If selected for a command assignment, officers must be capable of completing all acquisition certification requirements within established guidelines (i.e., they must already be an acquisition corps member upon assumption of command or able to achieve the appropriate certification level within 18 months from the command assignment start date).

3.2. **Minimum Criteria for All Nominees.** All officers competing for Test Eagle must meet the following minimum criteria:

3.2.1. Have not applied for separation or retirement.

3.2.2. Have not been deferred to the next higher grade.

3.2.3. Do not have a current unfavorable information file.

3.2.4. Have Defense Acquisition Workforce Improvement Act Test and Evaluation Level II certification.

3.2.5. Are either a lieutenant colonel, a lieutenant colonel select, a major in-the-promotion zone, or a major below-the-promotion zone to lieutenant colonel.

3.2.6. Are not be in the primary zone for promotion to colonel.

3.2.7. Have not served previously as the commander of a flying unit.

3.2.8. Are available to assume command during the entire time period the list encompasses.

3.3. Flight Test Squadron and Test Wing Operations Support Squadron Commander. Eligible AFSCs: 11XX, 12XX and 18XX:

3.3.1. Candidates must be current in their major weapon system or previously current within five years of the date they would assume command.

3.4. **Test Squadron Commander.** Eligible AFSCs: 11XX, 12XX, 13B/N/S, 17XX, 18XX and 6XXX.

3.5. **Eligibility Waivers.** Officers who do not meet the above eligibility criteria must submit a memorandum signed by their nominating official (see **paragraph 4.1**) requesting a waiver. The memorandum must state which criteria need to be waived and provide justification. The Director of AFMC/A3/6 is the approval authority for eligibility waivers.

4. Nomination Procedures.

4.1. **Table 1** establishes the appropriate level for nominating officials. Multiple nominations from the same wing, program office, or headquarters should be consolidated and submitted together when feasible.

Table 1. Nominating Officials.

If the nominee is serving in:	Then the nominating official is:
HAF, Joint, MAJCOM, NAF, or Center Staff	First General Officer or equivalent
Test or Operational Wing	Wing Commander
Systems Program Office (SPO) or Lab	SPO Director or equivalent (2-Letter)
In-residence education (e.g., PME or AFIT)	Department Chair or equivalent (Desired)

4.2. Candidates electing to compete for squadron command must complete the Test Eagle Board Application and have it endorsed by their nominating official or designee.

4.3. The Test Eagle Board Application will be made available on the AFMC/A3/6 SharePoint site and the address will be provided in the PSDM.

4.4. The applicant's signature on the application is an implicit agreement to accept any worldwide command opportunity when offered.

4.5. The nominating official's signature on the application is considered an implicit agreement to release the individual for any worldwide command opportunity offered.

4.6. Nominating officials must stratify all of their nominees utilizing X over Y, where Y is the number of nominees in each of two categories--rated and non-rated. For example, "3/8 rated," or "My #2 of 5 non-rated candidates," are acceptable stratification remarks. Nominating officials will not create stratifications by combining these two categories. A statement such as "#1/13 candidates" is inappropriate, because it combines rated and non-rated candidates into a single category.

4.7. Nominating officials for rated officers should review the candidate's AF Forms 942, Record of Evaluation, to ensure the member meets the high standards required of the developmental test community.

5. Board Preparation.

5.1. **Board Objectives.** The fundamental purpose of the Test Eagle board is to identify officers through a fair and competitive selection process that advances the best qualified officers to positions of increased responsibility and authority and provides the necessary career incentive to attract and maintain a quality officer force.

5.2. **Board Governance.** When the board is in session, it works directly for the Director of AFMC/A3/6 under the supervision of the board president. No person may:

5.2.1. Direct a particular individual be selected or not selected by the board.

5.2.2. Censure, reprimand, or admonish the board or any member of the board for exercising any function within the discretion of the board.

5.2.3. Attempt to coerce or influence any action of a board or any member of a board in formulating the board's recommendations.

5.3. **Board Location/Support.**

5.3.1. The Test Eagle board will convene at AFPC.

5.3.2. AFMC/A3F is the OPR for determining projected command vacancies, establishing whether nominees meet eligibility requirements, working with AFPC for all protocol and hospitality issues for the board, conducting the Test Eagle board, and releasing the list of candidate selects.

5.4. **Selection of Board Members.** AFMC/A3/6 ensures that board membership consists of at least seven or more officers who have at least been selected for promotion to colonel and have previously served as an AFMC squadron commander or materiel leader. Board duty will rotate between the maximum number of eligible officers over time.

5.5. **Board President.** The Director of AFMC/A3/6, or their designated representative, will serve as the board president and will:

5.5.1. Oversee the conduct of the board, including approving "rescores", monitoring discussions, and resolving splits and ties.

5.5.2. Ensure the consideration of all eligible officers without prejudice or partiality in a consistent, fair, and equitable manner.

5.6. **Board Members.** Each member of the Test Eagle command candidate selection board will:

5.6.1. Perform their duties based on the best interests of the Air Force.

5.6.2. Not represent or sponsor any particular career field, command, or any other category of officers.

5.7. **Board Recorders.** The AFPC career field functional managers for test and evaluation personnel serve as the board recorders. They will ensure procedures outlined in this instruction and board proceedings meet all requirements of law and Air Force policies. The board recorders will manage the flow of records to the board members, answer administrative questions, review information for presentation to the board, and advise the board president and members on board processes and other administrative matters.

5.8. **Administrative Support Staff.** AFMC/A3F personnel may assist the board recorders with the distribution and collection of records as well as other administrative tasks.

5.9. **Information Meets the Board.** The board will review the following documents for each command candidate:

5.9.1. The Test Eagle Application

5.9.2. The career summary single unit retrieval format.

5.9.3. All officer performance reports, training reports and decoration citations.

5.9.4. Letters to the Board from candidates.

6. Conducting the Board.

6.1. **Board Pre-Brief.** AFMC/A3F administrative support to the board will brief the board members on the purpose of the board and provide administrative remarks, pacing and scoring, and appropriate squadron and candidate information.

6.2. **Reviewing Records.** The board will consider records in the same competitive category before moving to the other category. All board members will score all records.

6.3. **Scoring Scales.** Boards will use **Table 2** Scoring Scale.

Table 2. Scoring Scale.

Score	Potential	Readiness For Command
10	**Outstanding**	**Absolutely Must Command**
9.5		**Ready For Command Now**
9.0		
8.5	**Above Average**	**Commander Candidate Now**
8.0		
7.5	**Average**	**Possible Future Commander Candidate**
7.0	**Below Average**	**Not A Commander Candidate**
6.5		
6.0		

6.4. **Defining Splits.** A split is a significant disagreement between board members about the score of a record. A split is considered a difference of two or more points between scores given by any two or more panel members (e.g., one board member gives a six and another board member gives an eight) to the same record.

6.5. **Resolving Splits.** All voting panel members must be present and may discuss the record involved in a split. Only panel members with split scores may change their scores in the process of resolving a split. If a nominee receives two or more scores that differ by two points or more, the board members responsible for those scores will rescore the record(s) to resolve the split. If a differential of two or more points remains after rescoring, the board president shall have authority to resolve the split in any manner they deem appropriate.

6.6. **Establishing the Quality Cut Line.**

6.6.1. After all scoring is complete, the board will establish an order of merit for each category and determine a cut line. The records above the cut line will be recommended for command.

6.6.2. If a vacancy exists in a specific category (for example, helicopter pilots) and the pool of qualified officers is below the cut line, the board president may bring forward the first qualified non-select to meet the requirement. In such a situation, the quality and reflective score of the eligible officer will be considered prior to selection.

6.7. **Candidate Selection.**

6.7.1. The board president will review the category lists to ensure the number of candidate selects is sufficient to meet all specialized requirements, (e.g., rated officers with fighter aircraft experience). If not, the board president may select the next highest scoring nominee(s) with that specialized qualification or experience. Normally, a nominee will not be moved above the cut off line if there are sufficient candidate selects meeting specialized requirements.

6.7.2. The Director of AFMC/A3/6 will approve the final list for release.

7. Post Board Actions. AFMC/A3F is responsible for all post board actions to include:

7.1. Staffing the Test Eagle List for all categories for the Director of AFMC/A3/6 approval.

7.2. Transmitting the Test Eagle list to AFPC for public release.

7.3. Distributing the approved list to the Centers, Wings and Groups for bids.

7.4. Collecting all bids and deconflicting any candidates selected by multiple squadron command/materiel leader boards with the AFMC Manpower, Personnel, and Services Directorate (AFMC/A1).

8. Disclosure of Board Proceedings, Findings, or Results. The score given any particular record is privileged information and will not be disclosed. There is no prohibition of disclosing information on the overall numbers considered, the manner in which the board was organized, the general procedures followed, or the number and grade of its membership. Board results shall not be disclosed until the Director of AFMC/A3/6 approves the list.

9. Squadron Commander Hiring Procedures.

9.1. AFMC/A3F will initiate the bidding process for hiring authorities. AFMC/A3F will task the hiring authorities to bid a minimum of three candidates for each opening.

9.2. All hiring authorities are expected to participate in the adjudication process.

9.3. SAF/AQH deconflicts materiel leader bids across the Air Force. AFMC hiring authorities should be prepared to defend their bids for any officers who were also selected as materiel leader candidates.

9.4. A waiver is required to hire an individual not on any command candidate list. In those rare instances when a waiver is required, the hiring authority will forward the request to AFMC/A3F for staff coordination to AFMC/CD for approval.

9.5. Test Eagle Candidate selects are considered a volunteer for any command opportunity offered during the entire period the list is in effect. If a candidate select refuses a command position, they will be removed from the Test Eagle list.

EVAN C. DERTIEN, Brig Gen, USAF
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Attachment 1

GLOSSARY OF REFERENCES AND SUPPORTING INFORMATION

References

AFPD 36-21, *Utilization and Classification of Air Force Military Personnel,* 20 Jun 2017

AFPD 36-26, *Total Force Development,* 18 Mar 2019

AFI 33-360, *Publications and Forms Management,* 01 Dec 2015

AFMAN 33-363, *Management of Records,* 01 Mar 2008

Prescribed Forms

None

Adopted Forms

AF Form 847, *Recommendation for Change of Publication*

Abbreviations and Acronyms

AF—Air Force

AFMAN—Air Force Manual

AFMC—Air Force Materiel Command

AFPC—Air Force Personnel Center

AFPD—Air Force Policy Directive

AFRIMS—Air Force Records of Information Management System

ANG—Air National Guard

HQ AFMC/A1—AFMC Manpower, Personnel, and Services Directorate

HQ AFMC/A3/6—AFMC Air, Space and Cyberspace Operations Directorate

HQ AFMC/A3F—AFMC Test and Evaluation Division

MAJCOM—Major Command

OPR—Office of Primary Responsibility or Officer Performance Report

RDS—Records Disposition Schedule